

Lawhive · Hackathon 2026



CASE BRIEF / MESSY, MODERATE

CASE 07

THE COUNCIL KEEPS FOBBING ME OFF ABOUT THE DAMP

V. 01

LONDON 30/05/26

MESSY, MODERATE



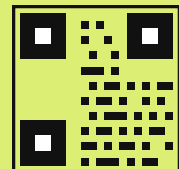
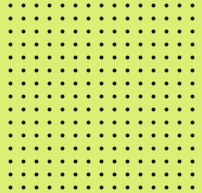
CLAIMANT

Crystal Bello

38, single mother, South London



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The council keeps fobbing me off about the damp

Crystal Bello, 38, single mother, South London

PROBLEM, IN THE CLIENT'S OWN WORDS

I've been dealing with damp and black mould in my council flat for about eight months now. It's mainly in my children's bedroom and the bathroom but it's started spreading into the hallway too.

I first reported it by phone. The council sent someone round after about three weeks, he said it was a 'condensation issue' and told me to open windows more and stop drying clothes indoors. I pushed back because I know it's not condensation, the walls are wet to the touch when it rains.

They eventually sent a contractor who put in a dehumidifier and fitted a new extractor fan in the bathroom. They asked me to sign a form when the work was done. I signed it, I thought I was just confirming they'd been, but looking back at it now I'm worried it might say I agreed the problem was fixed. The wording is a bit ambiguous.

The mould came back within a month, worse than before. My youngest has developed a persistent cough and our GP has written a letter saying the living conditions may be contributing to it.

I've sent about 15 emails to the council since this started, with photos, chasing for updates. Their replies have been patchy, mostly just acknowledging my emails and saying they'll investigate further. Two months ago I was assigned a new case handler who hasn't contacted me once.

I don't know what I'm supposed to do next. I haven't made a formal complaint or sent any kind of legal letter. A friend mentioned something about a 'pre-action protocol' but I don't know what that means. I just want my children to live somewhere safe.

KEY INFORMATION

Client	Crystal Bello
Property	Flat 38 Westwood House, Tilman Estate, Lambeth Road, SE1 7QF
Landlord	Southwark Council
Issue duration	Approximately 8 months
Affected rooms	Children's bedroom, bathroom, hallway
Health impact	Persistent cough in youngest child, GP letter on file

DOCUMENTS PROVIDED

#	FILENAME	DESCRIPTION
01	tenancy_agreement.pdf	Council tenancy agreement confirming Crystal as the tenant.
02	council_inspection_report.pdf	

#	FILENAME	DESCRIPTION
		Inspector's report from the initial visit, describing the issue as 'condensation related' and recommending improved ventilation.
03	mould_photos_month_1/	Five photos taken when the mould was first noticed. Children's bedroom walls and bathroom ceiling.
04	mould_photos_month_3/	Eight photos after the mould returned post remediation, visibly worse and spreading to the hallway.
05	mould_photos_month_8/	Eight recent photos showing extensive mould across three rooms, plus belongings affected.
06	contractor_works_form.pdf	The form Crystal signed when the dehumidifier was installed. 'Acknowledgment of Works Completed', 'I confirm that the above works have been carried out to my satisfaction'.
07	gp_letter.pdf	GP letter stating Crystal's youngest child has a persistent cough and 'the described living conditions may be a contributing factor'.
08	email_chain_with_council.pdf	Full email chain of 15 messages over eight months. Replies include 'we have noted your concern', 'a further inspection will be arranged', 'your case has been reassigned'.
09	phone_call_log.pdf	Log Crystal kept in her phone's notes app recording dates and summaries of calls to the council, including names of people she spoke to.